BLACKOUT READY

Your household power outage plan

A practical guide with printable checklists and space to build your own household plan.

01 — 02 — 03 — 04

WATER / FOOD / HYGIENE / COMMUNICATION

PREPARE. ORGANIZE. STAY CALM.

01

Make this plan yours

Start with a manageable step

Your goal

Prepare your household for a power outage in practical stages. Start with what you already own and fill specific gaps. This booklet is a planning tool; it does not promise supplies or safety for a fixed number of days.

Your first review

Work through water, food, lighting, hygiene and communication. Complete the worksheets and keep a printed copy with your supplies. Discuss the plan with everyone in your household.

Individual needs

Plan separately for children, older adults, disabilities, pets and medical equipment. Anyone relying on powered medical devices needs a backup and evacuation plan agreed in advance with their care and equipment providers.

Limits and help

Follow current local official instructions. Seek help and leave unsafe areas when there is immediate danger. Write your local emergency number on the household plan. This booklet does not replace medical advice or recognized first aid training.

- [ ] Keep supplies and a grab bag in a known location
- [ ] Make sure everyone knows the plan and meeting place
- [ ] Review every six months and after household changes

02

When the power goes out

Your first actions

Check safety first

Use a flashlight. Check whether anyone is injured or needs urgent support. If you notice smoke, a gas smell or another immediate hazard, move to safety and contact the appropriate emergency service from a safe location.

Understand the situation

If safe, check whether nearby properties are affected. Use a battery-powered radio and official updates. Stay away from damaged power lines and do not open electrical equipment.

Stabilize the household

Keep refrigerators and freezers closed. Switch off cooking appliances and sensitive electronics. Leave one safe light switched on so you can see when power returns.

Conserve communication power

Contact your agreed person if networks are available. Use brief messages, reduce screen brightness and keep a charged power bank ready. Do not call emergency lines for general outage information.

- [ ] Account for everyone in the household
- [ ] Follow official updates
- [ ] Keep cold appliances closed
- [ ] Use the agreed contact and meeting plan

03

Organize your water

Plan drinking and hygiene needs separately

Write down your needs

Record the number of people, planning days and daily drinking and cooking water needs. Use current local authority recommendations. Heat, illness and individual needs may increase requirements. Add hygiene water and pet needs separately.

Store safely

Use factory-sealed bottles or clean containers approved for drinking water. Store in a cool, dark place away from chemicals. Label containers you fill yourself and check your stock regularly.

Take advisories seriously

Follow local instructions during a drinking water advisory. Boiling does not remove chemical contamination. Household filters do not make all water safe; check the manufacturer’s stated capabilities and limitations.

Make access practical

Keep drinking water accessible. Clearly label non-drinking water and store it separately. Never use containers that previously held fuel, cleaners or other hazardous substances.

- [ ] Calculate drinking and cooking water on the supply sheet
- [ ] Add hygiene and pet needs
- [ ] Plan clean containers and stock rotation

04

Food without power

Supplies that fit your everyday life

Choose simple options

Favor shelf-stable foods your household already eats and tolerates. Include ready-to-eat meals, a manual can opener and foods needing little or no water. Account for allergies and special diets.

Protect cold storage

Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed and use an appliance thermometer. Food safety depends on temperature, time and food type. Check current official food safety tables rather than assuming all stored food is safe.

Never taste-test safety

Harmful bacteria cannot reliably be detected by smell or appearance. Do not taste questionable food to decide whether it is safe. When in doubt, discard perishable food.

Prepare meals safely

Plan meals without open flames where possible. Never use grills, charcoal or generators inside a home, garage or basement. An open window does not make indoor use safe. Use camping stoves only in the setting explicitly permitted by the manufacturer.

- [ ] Plan three easy meals without electricity
- [ ] Keep a manual can opener available
- [ ] Record expiry checks and stock rotation

05

Hygiene and health

Plan for cleanliness and care

Hands and waste

Include soap, clean water, toilet paper, personal hygiene items and suitable waste bags. Wash hands especially after toilet use and before eating. Follow local instructions for water use and waste collection.

Toilets and wastewater

If water or sewage service fails, check local guidance. Stop flushing if sewage backs up. Prepare an appropriate alternative and keep human waste away from food and water sources.

Medication planning

Keep an up-to-date medication list and contact details for your clinician and pharmacy. Discuss supplies, cooling requirements and continuity of care in advance. Do not change doses yourself; temperature-sensitive medicines have product-specific requirements.

Prepare for first aid

Keep an accessible first aid kit and refresh skills through a recognized course. Store essential health information on paper as well as digitally. Seek professional help for serious symptoms or injuries.

- [ ] Add personal hygiene and care products
- [ ] Agree medication and equipment plans with professionals
- [ ] Check the first aid kit and refresh training

06

Warmth, light and contact

Reduce avoidable risks

Choose flameless lighting

Use LED flashlights and headlamps where possible. Store suitable batteries. Check smoke alarms and, where appropriate, carbon monoxide alarms according to manufacturer instructions. An alarm never replaces safe appliance use.

Watch the temperature

Use layers and blankets in cold conditions. In hot weather, avoid direct sun and strenuous activity. Move to a safe alternative location early if your home becomes too hot or cold for your household.

Prevent carbon monoxide exposure

Operate generators outdoors only, far from doors, windows and vents, following manufacturer and local authority guidance. Never feed power into household wiring without professionally installed transfer equipment.

Stay connected

Choose a nearby meeting place and an alternative outside your neighborhood. Agree on an out-of-area contact. Arrange voluntary support with neighbors while protecting private information.

- [ ] Keep a flashlight within reach at night
- [ ] Test the radio and batteries
- [ ] Write down meeting places and a contact person

07

My household plan

Complete together and keep accessible.

Household / number of people / pets

Out-of-area contact / phone

Nearby meeting place

Alternative meeting place / safe place to stay

Individual needs / agreed support

Local emergency number / clinician / pharmacy

Location of supplies, radio and first aid kit

Reviewed on / next review date

08

Supplies and next actions

Fill specific gaps instead of buying at random.

Category / item	In stock	Add / review
Drinking and cooking water		
Hygiene water / pets		
Ready-to-eat food		
Special dietary needs		
Can opener / utensils		
Lights / batteries		
Radio / power banks		
Hygiene / waste bags		
First aid / personal care		
Medication continuity plan		
Documents / cash		
Grab bag / clothing		

Water planning: ____ people × ____ days × ____ liters per day = ____ liters. Additional needs: ____ liters. Check assumptions against local guidance.

My next three actions

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

09

Resources and next steps

Current official instructions take priority.

These official resources provide further guidance. Check current content and the rules for your location before use. This English edition is a general international version; add your local emergency numbers and regional requirements.

BBK · Deutschland / Germany

https://www.bbk.bund.de/

Ready.gov · Power outages

https://www.ready.gov/power-outages

Ready.gov · Emergency supplies

https://www.ready.gov/kit

FoodSafety.gov · Food safety during outages

https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/food-safety-during-power-outage

CDC · Carbon monoxide prevention

https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/about/

Before the next outage

- ☐ Discuss the plan with everyone in your household
- ☐ Test lights and radio; charge power banks
- ☐ Check the contact list and meeting places together
- ☐ Put new supplies behind older stock
- ☐ Schedule the next review

General planning guidance, not individual medical or technical advice. No guarantee of coping with a specific outage duration. Not affiliated with the authorities listed. Edition 1.0 · 2026.

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